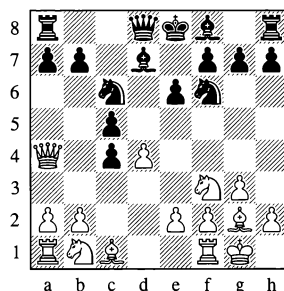




Catalan 4...dxc4



5...c5, 6...♘c6 and 7...♙d7

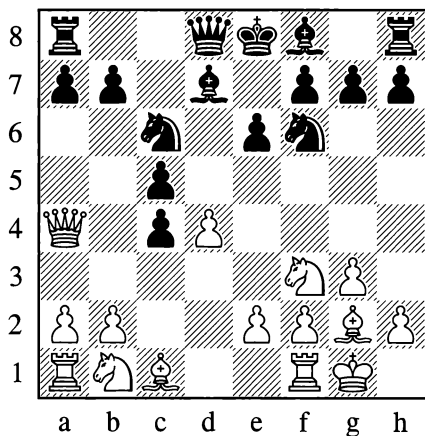
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1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 c5 6.0-0 ♘c6 7.♙a4 ♙d7

8.♙xc4

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1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 c5 6.0-0 ♘c6 7.♚a4 ♙d7



8.♚xc4

In *GM 1* I wrote that 8.dxc5 ♘a5 9.♚c2 ♙xc5 10.♘e5 ♚c8 is fine for Black, and nothing has happened since then to make me change my mind.

In this position there are four moves for us to consider: A) 8...♚c8, B) 8...♚b6, C) 8...b5 and D) 8...cxd4.

A) 8...♚c8

This looks natural, but Black will have to compromise his position to regain the pawn after White's next move.

9.dxc5 ♚a5

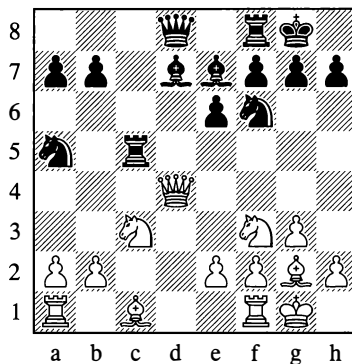
Black may also try:

9...♘a5 10.♚h4?

I decided to go in a new direction, since my previous suggestion 10.♚d3 does not seem fully convincing. 10...♙xc5 11.♘e5 0-0 12.♘c3 ♙c6 13.♚xd8 ♚fxd8 14.♘xc6 ♘xc6 15.♙f4 I evaluated this as slightly better for White in *GM 1*, but after 15...♙d4! 16.♚ac1 ♙xc3!N 17.♚xc3 ♘d5 Black seems to be fine.

10...♚xc5 11.♘c3 ♙e7 12.♚d4 0-0

This position occurred in Molnar – Honfi, Budapest 1950, and a couple of subsequent games. Here I found an interesting new idea:

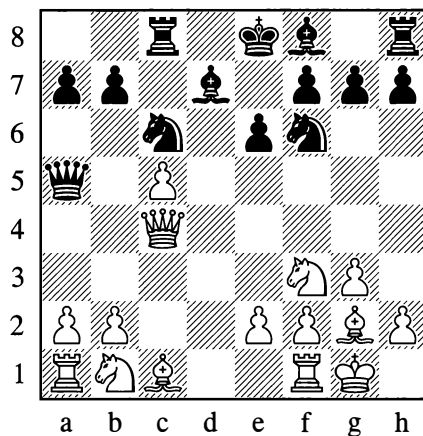


13.♚d3!N ♘c4

The main point is that 13...♙c6 runs into 14.♚xd8 ♚xd8 15.♙e3 ♚h5 16.♙xa7 winning a pawn.

14.b3 ♘b6 15.e4 ♚c8 16.♙b2 ♚d8 17.♚fc1±

White's space advantage makes the difference.



10.♘fd2!N

My previous recommendation of 10.♙g5 ♚xc5 11.♘bd2 now looks pretty innocent to me, but this new idea seems more challenging.

10...♚xc5

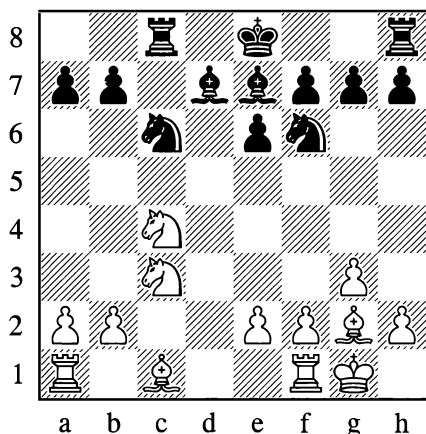
10...♙xc5?? would run into 11.♘b3.

11.♘c3 ♚xc4

11...dxa5 12.♖d3 ♘c6 13.dde4! dxe4
14.dxe4 ♖c4 15.♗e3 also gives White some
advantage.

12.dxc4 ♘e7

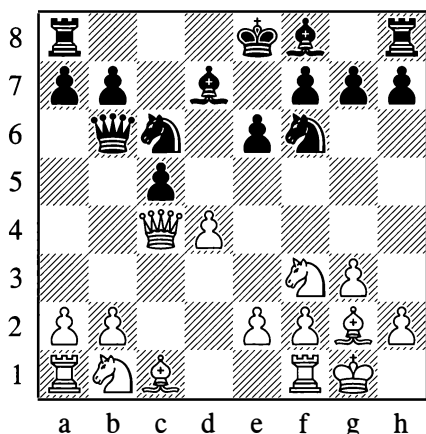
12...d4 runs into 13.dxe5 ♘c6 14.dxc6
dxc6 15.♘e3 and White is clearly better,
thanks to his bishop pair.



13.♘f4 0-0 14.♗fd1 ♗fd8 15.♗ac1 ♘e8
16.d6 ♘xd6 17.♘xd6±

The bishop pair gives White a lasting
advantage.

B) 8...♗b6



9.dxc5

Here Black may opt for B1) 9...dxc5 or B2)
9...♗xc5.

B1) 9...dxc5 10.dxc3

And now we have another split between B1)
10...dxa5 and B12) 10...♗b4.

After 10...0-0 11.d4 ♖b4 12.♗xc5 ♗xa4
it's obvious that White is much better with his
bishop pair. The most convincing continuation
seems to be 13.b3 ♗a6 14.e3 ♗ac8 15.♘b2
dxe4 16.♗h5 with a nice edge for White,
Konik – Grass, Frankfurt 2006.

10...♘e7 11.♘e3 ♗a5

After 11...♗b4 White can even trade queens:
12.♗xb4 (12.♗d3 is also fine.) 12...dxb4
Hoelzl – Tsomis, Olympus 2011, and now
the aggressive 13.dxe5!N would have been
strong. There is no need to fear 13...dxc2
14.♗ac1 dxe3 15.fxe3 ♗b8 16.♗fd1 when
White has a lot of pressure.

12.a3 0-0

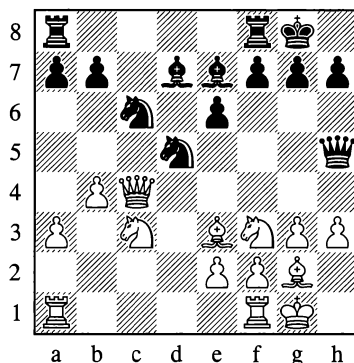
12...♗c8 13.♗fd1 0-0 occurred in Nemeth
– Seres, Hungary 2012. Here the right idea
to seize the initiative is 14.♗b5!N ♗fd8
15.♗ac1 (15.dxe1! also deserves attention)
15...♗xb5 16.dxb5 a6 17.d6 ♘xd6
18.♗xd6 ♘e8 19.♗xd8 ♗xd8 20.♘b6± and
the bishop pair is significant.

13.b4 ♗h5 14.h3!

Highlighting the misplacement of the black
queen.

14...d5

Now in Stanciu – Bazaj Bockai, Bled (ol)
1992, White should have played:



15. ♖xd5! N ♗xd5

Or 15...exd5 16. ♗b5! intending 16...♗ab8
17. ♕xa7!±.

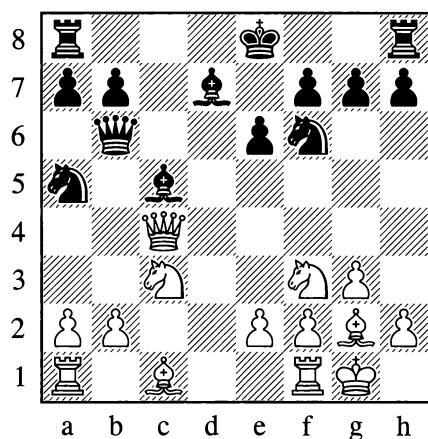
16. ♖d2!

The IQP position would be favourable, but this is even stronger.

16...♗xc4 17. ♖xc4

White's advantage is obvious.

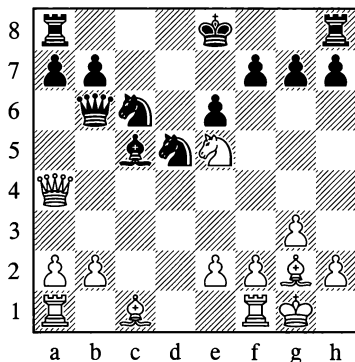
B11) 10...♖a5



This has been the most popular move in the position, but Black has scored miserably against White's next move.

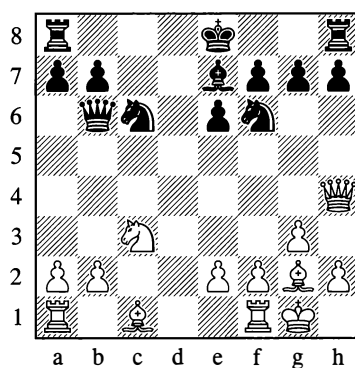
11. ♗h4! 0-0

11...♕c6?! 12. ♖a4 (12. ♕h6!? is also excellent) 12...♕xa4 13. ♗xa4† ♖c6 14. ♖e5 ♖d5

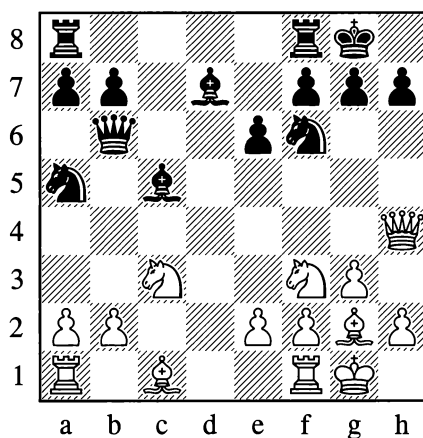


15.a3 gives White a clear advantage, and Black found a way to lose on the spot with 15...♗c8? 16. ♕xd5 exd5 17. ♗g4!+ in Buhmann – Bax, Hengelo 2000.

11...♕e7 12. ♖e5 ♕c6 13. ♖xc6 ♖xc6 also leaves Black well short of equality. Here is a good example of what might happen:



14. ♗a4 ♗c8 15. ♗b1 a6?! (16...0-0 is better, though White remains on top after: 17. ♕e3 ♕c5 18. ♕xc5 ♗xc5 19. ♗bc1±) 16. ♕e3 ♕c5 17. ♕xc5 ♗xc5 18. ♗fc1 White does not even need the bishop pair, as his Catalan bishop was powerful enough to secure a clear plus in Brito Garcia – Aleman Alamo, Las Palmas 2010.



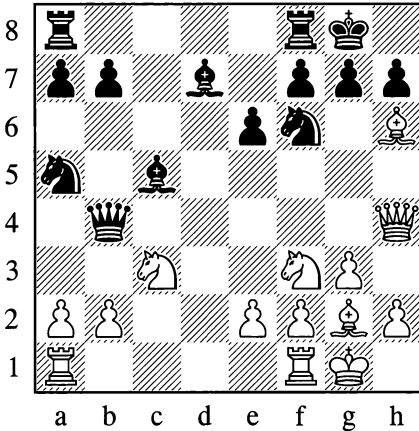
12. ♕h6!N

White has other ways to secure an advantage, but this is the most convincing. It's also a

thematic idea for this variation, of which we will see a few more examples later in the chapter.

12...♖b4

12...♖e8 does not help, as 14.♖e5 gives White a considerable advantage.



13.♖g5!

This follow-up is key. Now White gets a big advantage with the following forced sequence.

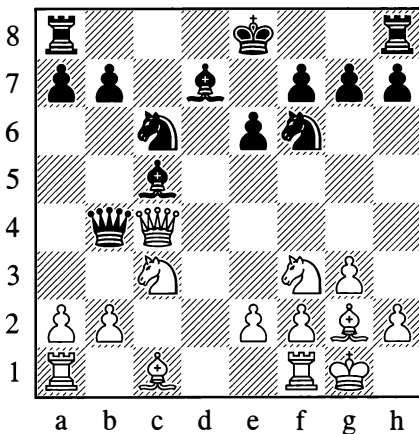
13...♖e8 14.a3 ♖xb2 15.♖xc5!?

15.♖xc7 ♖xc7 16.♖e4 is a simpler route to a clear plus.

15...♖b3 16.♖b4 a5 17.♖xb7 ♖xc3 18.♖ab1 ♖c6 19.♖xc7! ♖xc7 20.♖xb3±

White emerges with a healthy extra pawn.

B12) 10...♖b4



11.♖d3!

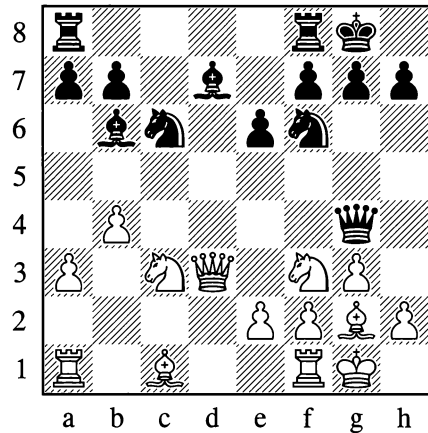
The black queen is rather vulnerable on b4, so White should avoid the exchange.

11...0-0

Black has also tried: 11...♖d8 12.a3 ♖g4 (12...♖b3? 13.♖d2 ♖b6 14.♖a4 ♖a5 occurred in Abhyankar – Rendon, Thessaloniki [ol] 1988, and here White could have secured a serious advantage with: 15.♖b3!N ♖xf2† 16.♖xf2 ♖xa4 17.♖c5 ♖d4 18.♖xd4 ♖xd4 19.♖xb7±) 13.♖f4 0-0 14.h3 ♖g6 15.♖xc6 hxc6 16.♖fd1 White had a typical Catalan advantage in Petrosian – Pomar Salamanca, Havana (ol) 1966.

12.a3 ♖g4 13.b4 ♖b6

Two games have reached this position, but White's play was not convincing. I would like to propose a simple improvement.



14.♖e3!N ♖f5

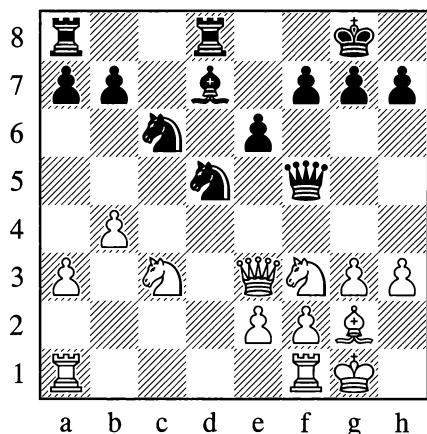
14...♖fd8?! 15.♖xb6 axb6 16.♖e3 leads to a similar situation where Black has the additional worry of weak queenside pawns.

15.♖d2!

Once again White should avoid the queen exchange, as the black queen is rather exposed on the fifth rank. The following line confirms White's advantage.

15...♙xe3 16.♖xe3 ♜fd8 17.h3! ♜d5

Otherwise the black queen may find herself in serious trouble.



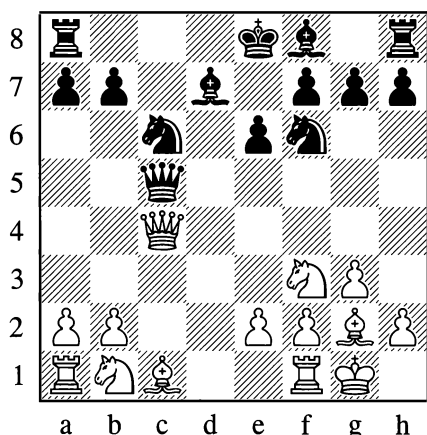
18.♜xd5 ♜xd5

18...exd5 19.♖ac1 leaves no doubt as to White's advantage.

19.♜fd1 ♜b5 20.♜d4

White maintains the pressure and is clearly better.

B2) 9...♜xc5

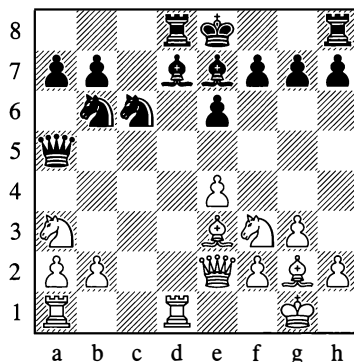


This seems like the more reliable choice, and it has been used by some strong players including Adams.

10.♜a3

Now most games have continued with either B21) 10...♙e7 or B22) 10...♜c8.

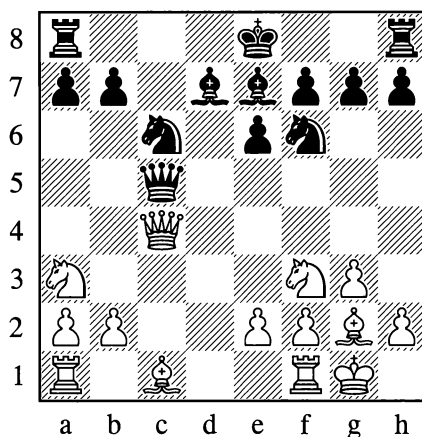
10...♜d5 has been tried a few times. Now 11.♜d1N seems like the most useful move, and after 11...♙e7 12.e4 ♜b6 13.♜e2 ♜d8 14.♙e3 ♜a5



15.♜b5 0-0 16.♙f1! White has a nice initiative.

10...♜a5 11.♜xc5 (11.♜h4!?N ♙e7 12.♜d1 is also worth considering.) 11...♙xc5 Now 12.♜e5N looks natural, and after 12...♜c8 13.♙d2 ♜c6 14.♜ac4 White will soon enjoy the advantage of the bishop pair, which should secure a long-term pull.

B21) 10...♙e7



Now that Black has wasted a tempo moving his bishop, it makes sense to exchange queens.

11.♙xc5 ♙xc5 12.♖c4 0–0

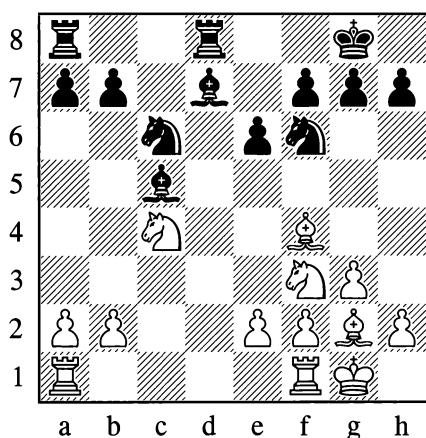
It is essential that White can meet 12...♖c8N with 13.♙e3!, and 12...♗e7 with 13.a3!. In both cases Black experiences problems on the dark squares.

12...♖d5 should be met by: 13.♖d1N (13.a3 occurred in Golovanj – Derjabin, Alushta 2005, but it is not so convincing after 13...♖c8 14.♙d2 f6.) 13...♖d8 14.a3 ♖b6 (Also after 14...0–0 15.b4 ♙e7 16.♙b2 f6 17.♖ac1 White is obviously better.) 15.♖ce5 f6 16.♖xd7 ♖xd7 17.♖xd7 ♗xd7 18.♙d2 ♖c4 19.♙c3± White's bishop pair gives him an enduring edge.

13.♙f4!?N

13.a3 is a sensible move which gave White a small plus in Arkell – Player, Bedford 2013. The text move poses more concrete problems for Black.

13...♖fd8



14.♙c7!

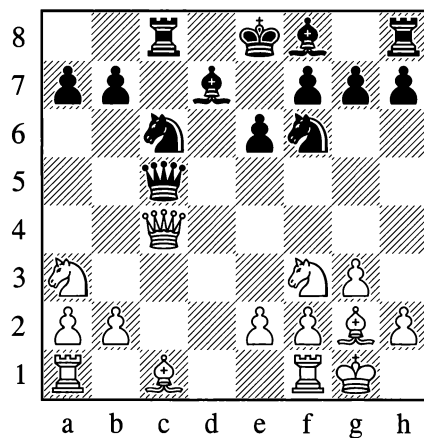
After 14.♖fd1 ♙e8 15.♙d6 ♖e4 16.♙xc5 ♖xc5 Black is close to equality.

14...♖dc8 15.♙d6 ♖d8 16.♖fe5 16.♖fd2 is a decent alternative.

16...♙b5 17.b3

White keeps some pressure.

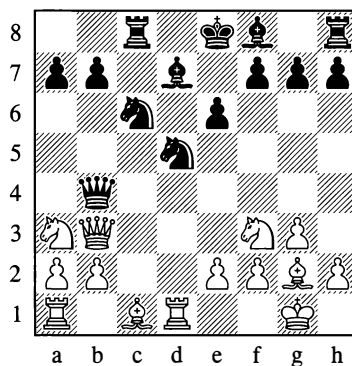
B22) 10...♖c8



11.♖d1 ♙e7

This is similar to the previous line, but the inclusion of the respective rook moves just changes things slightly.

11...♖d5 12.♙b3 ♙b4

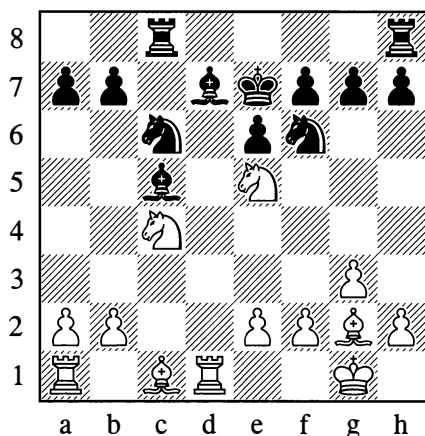


13.♙d3! ♙g4? 14.e4 ♖b6 15.♖c4 gave White a decisive advantage in Garnica – Benyounes, corr. 2012.

11...♙b6 12.♙h4! ♙e7 (In the event of

12...♙xa3 13.bxa3 h6 14.♙g5 ♘d5 15.♞ab1 ♜c7 16.♞dc1 Black is under considerable pressure.) 13.♘c4 ♜b4 14.b3 ♜b5 15.♙g5 White had a huge advantage in Andersen – Dasaolu, Gibraltar 2011.

12.♜xc5 ♙xc5 13.♘c4 ♖e7 14.♘fe5



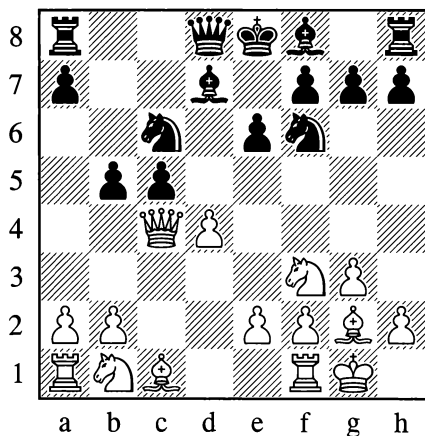
14...♞hd8N

14...♙e8? 15.♘d3 was nasty for Black in Cifka – Simek, Prague 2011. The text move is a better try, but I found a nice reply for White.

15.♙xc6! ♙xc6 16.♞xd8 ♞xd8 17.♘xc6† bxc6 18.♙d2‡

White's superior pawn structure gives him a long-term edge.

C) 8...b5



This active move remains quite popular.

9.♜d3

Obviously 9.♜xb5? is not working for White, since after 9...♘xd4 10.♜c4 Black has 10...♙b5!.

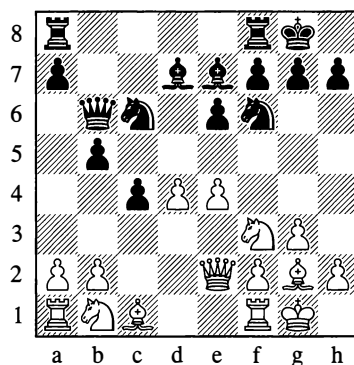
Now Black has two major options: C1) 9...c4 and C2) 9...♞c8.

C1) 9...c4 10.♜c2 ♞c8

This looks like the most natural continuation, as Black will most likely wish to remove his rook from the h1-a8 diagonal at some point.

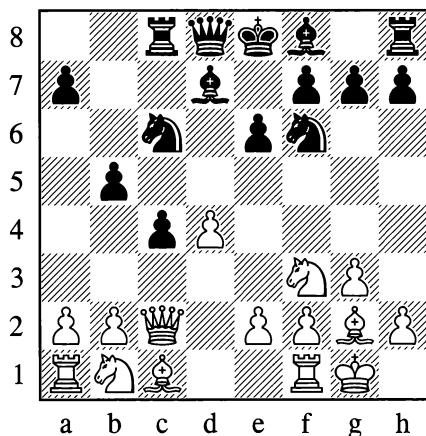
10...♘b4?! 11.♜d1 ♙c6 is revealed to be dubious after 12.a3 ♘a6 (or 12...♘bd5 13.♘e5 ♙b7 14.e4 ♘b6 15.♘c3 a6 16.♙e3 and White's advantage is obvious) 13.♘c3 ♘c7 14.e4 when White had a clear advantage in Stean – Ristic, Smederevska Palanka 1982.

10...♙e7 has been quite a popular choice in recent years. Here I like the relatively unexplored 11.e4 0-0 12.♜e2 ♜b6, and now the new idea:



13.♙e3N (13.♞d1 ♞fe8 was played in Wen Yang – Xiu Deshun, Ningbo 2011. I couldn't find anything special here; it's just an extremely complex position.) 13...♘g4 The logical reply, as the black queen did not have a convenient

retreat square. 14.♙f4 ♖ad8 15.h3 ♜f6 16.♞d1 The position remains complex, but I like White's pawn centre. A possible continuation is 16...♙e8 17.♙e3 ♞b8 18.♜e1 a6 19.♜c2 when White has a harmonious position with good central control. Possible pawn breaks include a2-a4, b2-b3 and d4-d5.

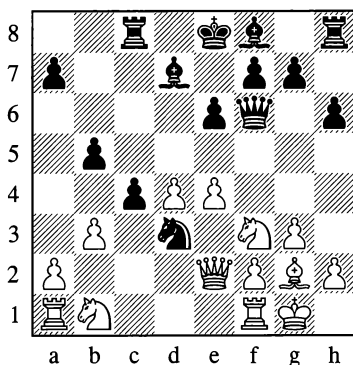


11.e4

11.♙g5 was my previous recommendation, but the following game, played after the release of *GM 1*, shows the right way for Black: 11...♙e7 12.♜c3 ♞b6 13.♖ad1 0-0 14.♜e5 ♜fd8 15.♜xd7 ♖xd7 Black was doing all right in Gourlay – Cernousek, Hinckley Island 2009.

11...♙e7

11...♜b4 12.♞e2 ♜d3 occurred in Sanna – Passerotti, Napoli 1981. Now I believe White should have tried 13.♙g5N, with the following point: 13...h6 14.♙xf6 ♞xf6 15.b3!



White is ready to meet 15...e5 with powerful play: 16.a4! exd4 17.e5 ♞b6 18.axb5 ♙xb5 19.bxc4 ♙xc4 20.♜bd2 Black has problems with his development.

11...♞b6 12.a4!?N

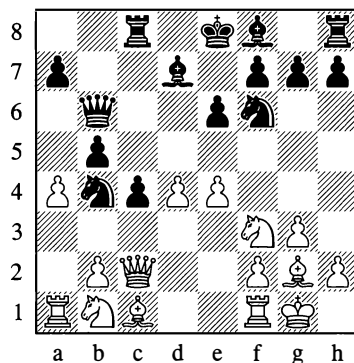
This looks like an interesting novelty, especially taking into account that after 12.♖d1 ♜b4 13.♞e2 ♜d3 Black was doing fine in Badea – Berescu, Brasov 2004.

12...♜b4

This looks critical, although it is worth checking a few other options:

12...a6 is too compliant, and after 13.axb5 axb5 14.♜c3 ♜b4 15.♞e2 ♜d3 16.♙g5 it is obvious that the opening of the a-file has benefited White.

12...♜xd4 13.♜xd4 ♞xd4 14.axb5 also favours White in view of 14...♞d3 15.♞a4 ♞b3 16.♜c3 ♙c5 17.♞xb3 cxb3 18.♙e3!, followed by grabbing the a-pawn with a clear advantage.



13.♞d1 bxa4

13...♜xe4? is too risky in view of 14.♜e5 ♜f6 15.♜xd7 ♜xd7 16.axb5 ♙e7 17.♜c3, followed by ♙e3 and ♞a4, with a clear advantage.

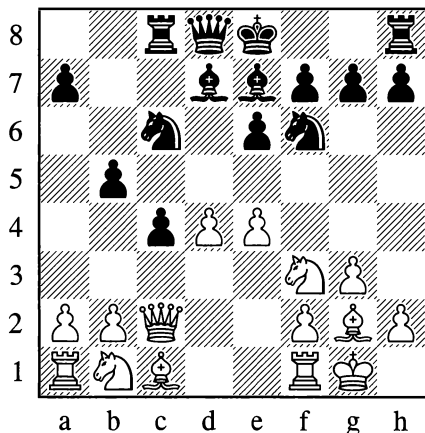
14.♜c3 ♜d3 15.♜xa4 ♞b3

Black is hanging on, but White's chances are better, for example:

16.♜c3 a5 17.♜e5 ♞xd1 18.♖xd1 ♜xe5 19.dxe5 ♜g4 20.♖xa5! ♙c5 21.♖xc5 ♖xc5

22.f4

Black will suffer with his knight on the edge of the board.



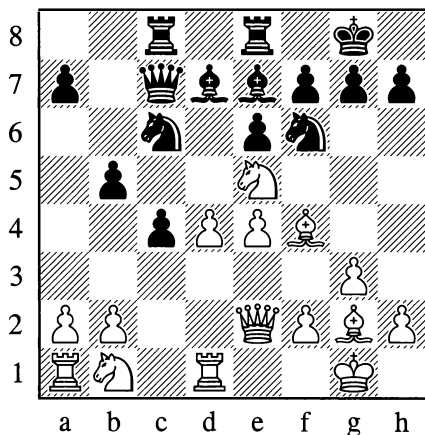
12.♖e2 0-0 13.♗d1

The position is playable for both sides, although it looks like a pretty good version for White compared with the 10...♗e7 line noted earlier.

13...♗e8 14.♖e5!

This idea was not available in the 10...♗e7 line. I found one practical example from this position, which we will follow for a few more moves.

14...♗c7 15.♗f4



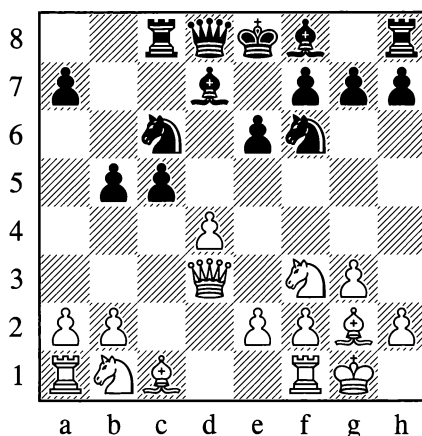
15...♗d6?

An unfortunate decision, but even after the improvement 15...♗b7 16.a4 a6 17.♗e3 ♖b4 18.♖c3 White maintains a nice edge.

16.♖xd7 ♖xd7 17.e5 ♗b4 18.a3 ♗f8 19.♖c3 a6 20.d5+

Black was in serious trouble in Badea – Itkis, Bucharest 2003.

C2) 9...♗c8



This way Black develops more fluidly but risks being saddled with some pawn weaknesses on the queenside.

10.dxc5 ♗xc5

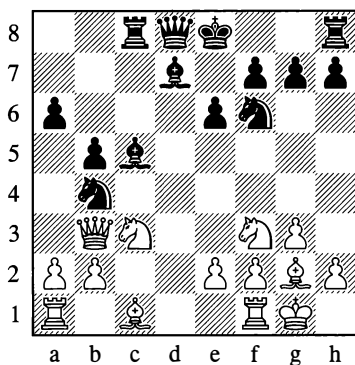
Worse is:

10...♖b4?! 11.♗b3! ♗xc5 12.♖c3 a6

12...♖bd5 13.♖xd5 ♖xd5 14.♖e5+ secures a clear advantage for White.

12...♗c6 13.a3 ♖bd5 was played in Tanacs – Izso, Kecskemet 2012, and here White missed the simple 14.♖e5N with a clear plus, in view of 14...♖xc3 15.♗xc6† ♗xc6 16.♖xc6 ♖xe2† 17.♖h1 ♗b6 18.♗f3!± when Black does not have enough for the exchange.

Now in Mate – Peredy, Hungary 2000, White could have got some advantage with:



13. ♟g5!N

The following analysis from *GM 1* still looks good:

13...♟c6 14.a3 ♜bd5 15.♞e5 ♟a8

15...♜xc3 runs into 16.♟xc6† ♞xc6 17.♜xc6 ♜xe2† 18.♞g2 ♞a8 19.♟xf6! ♞xc6† 20.♞f3 with a decisive advantage.

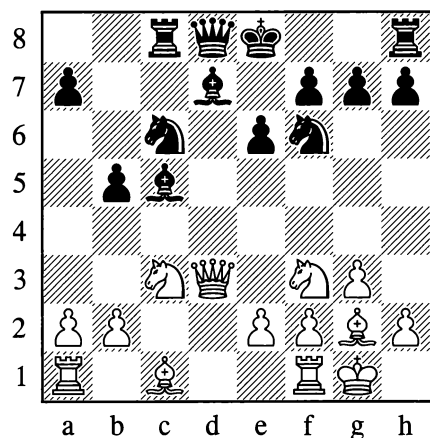
16.♞ac1 ♜xc3 17.♞xc3 ♟xg2 18.♞xg2 ♞d5† 19.♞xd5 ♜xd5 20.♞c2!

The pin along the c-file decides.

20...f6 21.♟xf6! gxf6 22.♜d3

White should eventually win the endgame with his extra pawn.

11.♞c3



At this point Black's three most important options are C21) 11...0-0, C22) 11...♜b4 and C23) 11...b4.

11...a6?!

This slow move gives White an easy initiative.

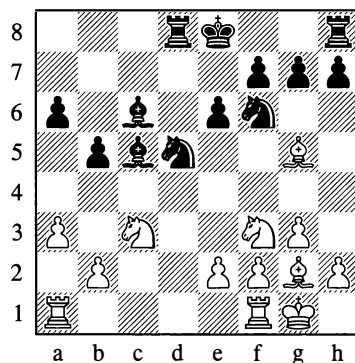
12.♟g5 ♜b4

This was a recent attempt to reanimate this line for Black.

12...h6 13.♟xf6 gxf6 (13...♞xf6? loses to 14.♜e4 ♞e7 15.♞c3!, attacking both the bishop and the g7-pawn) 14.♞ad1 ♟e7 15.♞d2± gave Black serious problems in Badea – Marjanovic, Bucharest 1998.

13.♞d2 ♟c6 14.♞xd8† ♞xd8 15.a3 ♜bd5

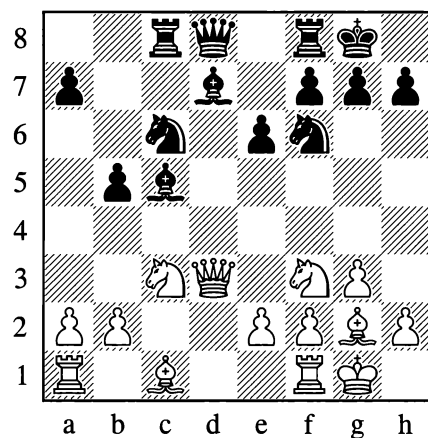
Even without queens, White has the makings of a strong initiative. In Farago – J. Pinter, Paks 2012, he should have played:



16.♞e5N ♟a8 17.♜xd5 ♟xd5 18.♞fd1

With a clear advantage.

C21) 11...0-0



This looks natural, but White can energetically exploit the disharmony of Black's pieces with:

12. ♖g5 ♘b4 13. ♙xf6 gxf6 14. ♜d2!

14. ♜e4 is also promising, but I like the idea of transferring the queen to h6.

14... ♙c6

14... ♙g7 guards the h6-square, but enables White to seize the initiative in the following instructive way: 15. a3 ♘a6 16. ♞ad1 (16. b4! is a good alternative, playing against the misplaced knight on a6.) 16... ♙c6 17. ♜f4 ♜c7 18. ♜g4† ♙h8 19. ♜h5± With an obvious advantage.

15. ♜h6 ♞e8

Intending ... ♙f8 to expel the queen.

15... ♜e7 16. a3!

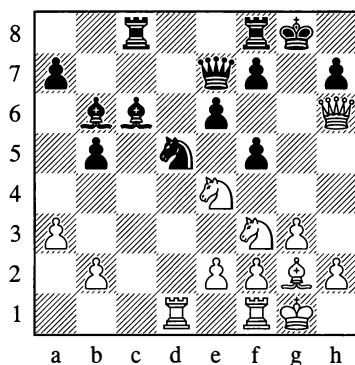
This recommendation from *GM 1* has since been tested in a few games.

16. ♞ad1 is less accurate due to 16... ♞fd8 17. a3 ♘c2! 18. ♞xd8† ♜xd8 and Black was fine in Pribyl – Ivkov, Nice 1974.

16... ♘d5

16... ♘a6 was tried in C. Horvath – Guido, Vaujany 2010. Here White could have played 17. ♞fd1N b4 18. axb4 ♘xb4 19. ♞a5! ♞fd8 20. ♞xd8† ♞xd8 21. g4!, followed by trading the light-squared bishops, with a clear advantage.

17. ♘e4 ♙b6 18. ♞ad1 f5



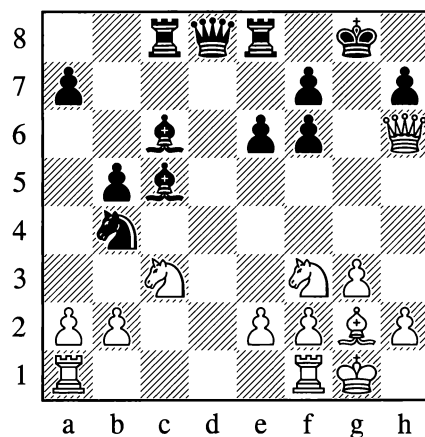
19. ♞xd5! f6 20. ♘xf6† ♞xf6

In *GM 1* I gave the almost identical 20... ♜xf6

21. ♜xf6 ♞xf6 22. ♞d2 ♙xf3 23. ♙xf3±.

21. ♜g5† ♜g7 22. ♜xg7† ♙xg7 23. ♞d2 ♙xf3 24. ♙xf3

The opposite-coloured bishops offer Black some chances to survive. Nevertheless, White was still able to convert his extra pawn in Reinhart – Gach, email 2011.



16. ♞ad1 ♙f8 17. ♜h5 ♜e7 18. a3

Black has some coordination problems, and the queen on h5 plays a key role in attacking the b5-pawn.

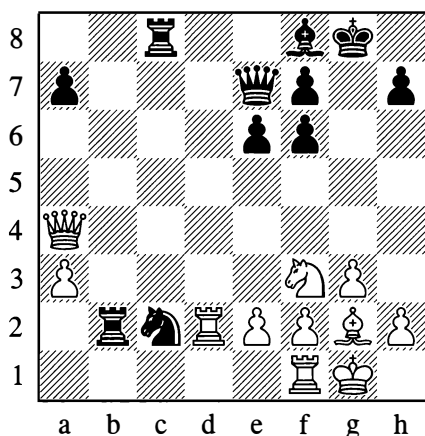
18... ♘c2

18... ♘d5? is refuted by 19. ♘d4!.

18... ♙xf3 19. ♙xf3 ♘c6 20. ♘xb5± gave White a healthy extra pawn and a clear advantage in Anastasian – Kaidanov, Lucerne 1997.

The text move was played in D. Berczes – D. Horvath, Budapest 2012. Here there was no reason to refrain from the obvious capture:

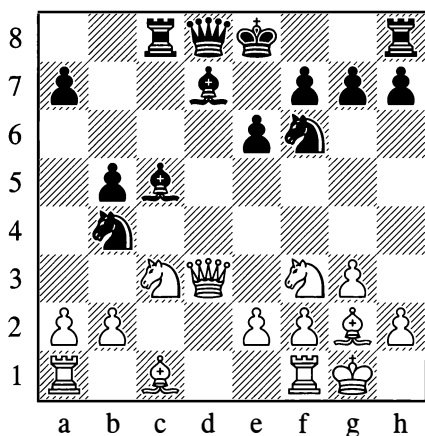
19. ♘xb5N ♙xb5 20. ♜xb5 ♞b8 21. ♜a4 ♞xb2 22. ♞d2 ♞c8

**23.f3!**

Black has serious coordination problems, and he cannot get away with taking the a3-pawn:

23...xa3 24.g4† h8 25.d7!

White has a decisive attack.

C22) 11...d4**12.d2!**

A deep study of this variation convinced me that the text is stronger than 12.d1. I won an easy game with the latter move after 12...c6 13.xd8† xd8 14.g5 e7? 15.a3 a6 16.e5 xg2 17.xg2± when Black was unable to avoid the loss of a pawn in Avrukh

– Moiseenko, Maalot 2008. However, a much better continuation is 14...0–0 15.ac1 c8 16.xf6 gxf6, when Black should hold without much trouble.

12...0–0

This has been played in several correspondence games.

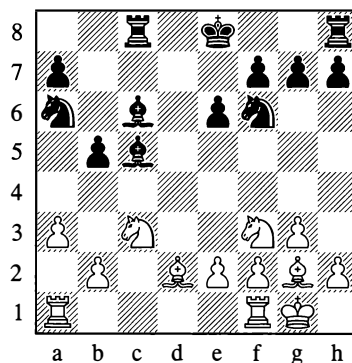
12...bd5 13.dxd5 dxd5 (13...exd5?! 14.b3 0–0 15.b2 gave White a stable advantage in Zhang Zhong – Wang Yu, Manila 2007.) This was Wessman – Jepson, Stockholm 1993, and now 14.e5N± leads to a typical situation where White's bishop pair gives him the advantage.

12...c6 13.a3 xd2N

13...bd5 14.e5! gave White a pleasant edge in Hase – Dodson, corr. 1994.

14.xd2 d6

14...bd5 15.e5!± is problematic for Black.

**15.b4 b6 16.ac1**

The misplaced knight on a6 is a serious factor, for instance:

16...0–0 17.e5 xg2 18.xg2 f8

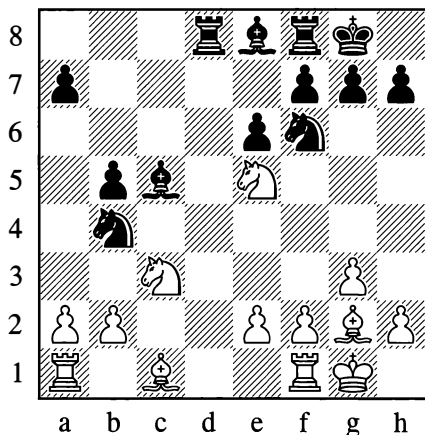
Both 18...c7 19.c6! and 18...d4 19.f4 xc3 20.xc3 leave White with a clear advantage.

19.f4

Black has a difficult position.

13.♘e5 ♙e8 14.♖xd8 ♜xd8

This position occurred in M.A. Dos Santos – Sutkalenko, Internet 2010, and several other games. Here I found a new idea:

**15.♙f4N**

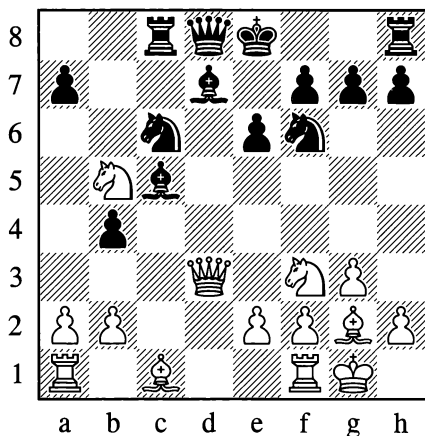
14.♙g5 h6 15.♙xf6 gxf6 has been played in all the games so far, but Black has been pretty successful at neutralizing White's slight initiative. That is why I prefer the slightly more reserved development of the bishop. A brief illustrative line is:

15...♘fd5 16.♙d2 f6 17.♘xd5 ♘xd5 18.♘d3 ♙b6 19.♝fc1

White has typical pressure on the queenside.

C23) 11...b4 12.♘b5

12.♘e4 has been played in quite a lot of games, but the text move is much more principled.

**12...0–0 13.♘d6!**

I also considered 13.♙f4 and 13.♙e3, but Black has clear paths to equality against both of them.

13...♘d4

This initiates serious complications, but White has a well-defined path to an advantage.

Black can hardly hope to equalize by giving up his dark-squared bishop: 13...♙xd6 14.♖xd6 ♖e7 15.♙f4 White had a definite advantage in Polujahov – Koniushev, Novorossiysk 1996.

13...♝c7

This rare yet interesting move has a hidden idea behind it.

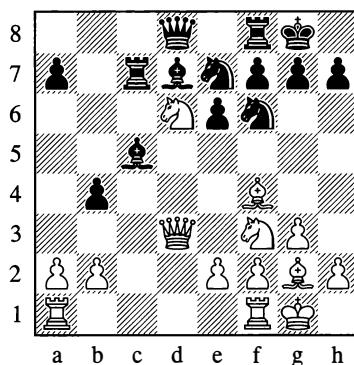
14.♙f4

Obviously the critical continuation. Stohl analysed it in *Chess Informant* 87, and it has been tested a couple of times since *GM I* was published.

14.♙g5 occurred in Verat – Hartereau, Paris 1991, and here the surprising 14...♙c8!N would have threatened ...♝d7. White must therefore simplify with 15.♘xc8 ♖xd3 16.exd3 ♝cxc8 17.♝ac1 ♙d6, when Black has the d5-square at his disposal, and I believe White's advantage is rather symbolic.

14...♘e7

14...♘d5? allows 15.♘g5+ and White wins material.



15. d5! d6 16. d4 dxe4

16... dxc8 occurred in Yotov – Davidov, email 2009. Here I propose 17. f3 18. d6! dxd6 19. dxf7 f7 20. dxd6 e7 21. dxc8 dxc8 22. eac1 b7 23. d4 when, despite the approximate material equality, White dominates the board.

17. dxe4

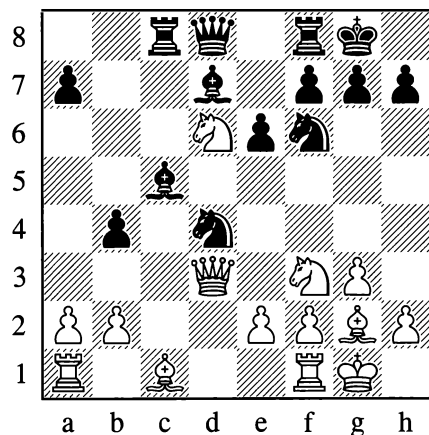
I also considered: 17. dxc7N dxf2 18. xg6 d4+ 19. h1 hxg6 (Stohl gives only 19... f6? 20. d8+.) Now a logical sequence is 20. d8 d8 21. dxf7 f8 22. f3 d2+ 23. g2 dxf7 24. eac1 b6 25. e2 f2 26. dxf2 c8 27. e8 dxc8 when the endgame looks drawish, although White can certainly play on for a while with no risk.

17... e5 18. e3 dxe3 19. xxe3 e7 20. eac1 f8 21. d5 e8 22. e8c7 e8c7

This position occurred in Petukhov – Rawlings, email 2009, and here I would prefer:

23. e8c1N±

Black's position has two clear drawbacks: the exposed queenside pawns and the misplaced knight on g6.

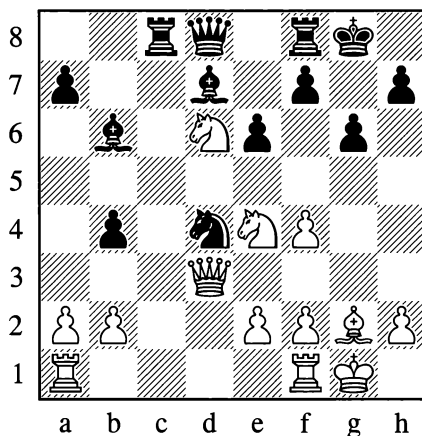


14. f4 d5 15. d5!

This is the point of White's play. The following sequence is relatively forced.

15... g6 16. dge4 dxf4 17. gxf4 b6!

Worse is 17... d6 18. dxc8 b5 19. h3 dxe2+ 20. h1 xxc8 (20... dxf4 21. h6 dxf1 22. e8f1+–) 21. eac1± with a material advantage to White.



18. dxc8 b5 19. d2!

This improvement was introduced by Stohl in 2003. Previously White had tried only 19. h3, with horrible results.

19... xxc8

After 19... dxe2+ 20. h1 xxc8 21. xxb4± White is the exchange up for no compensation, and has achieved a huge score from this position.

20. e3 dxf1 21. e8f1 d5

21... f5 22. d3 c2 23. xxb4± was similar in Stohl – A. Sokolov, Germany 2003.

22. xxb4±

White was a pawn up for minimal compensation in Bang – Kuiper, email 2006, and several subsequent games. Black ended up drawing quite a few of them, but I cannot see why anyone would want to defend such a position.

D) 8...cxd4 9.♟xd4

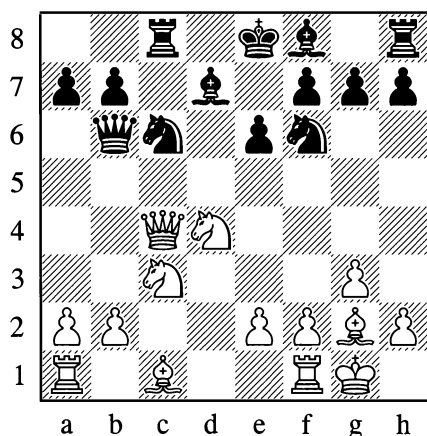
Several top GMs have played this way with Black. Compared with the previous variation, he avoids weakening the queenside and tries to neutralize White's opening initiative.

9...♞c8

9...♟xd4 10.♞xd4 ♟c6 11.♟xc6† bxc6 is occasionally seen, but the weakening of Black's pawn structure gives White an automatic advantage. Here I suggest the simple 12.♟e3N ♞xd4 13.♟xd4 c5 14.♟xf6 gxf6 15.♟a3 f5 16.♟c4 ♟g7 17.♞ad1 ♟e7 18.♞d3± with an unpleasant endgame for Black.

10.♟c3

Here we will consider **D1) 10...♞b6**, **D2) 10...♟e7** and **D3) 10...♟xd4**, the last of which is the main line by far.

D1) 10...♞b6

Black is trying to provoke an exchange on c6.

11.♟b3?!

In *GM 1* I gave 11.♟xc6 ♟xc6 12.♟e3, but I discovered an unpleasant surprise in 12...♟c5!. All other moves were working perfectly for White, but now I don't see how we can pose

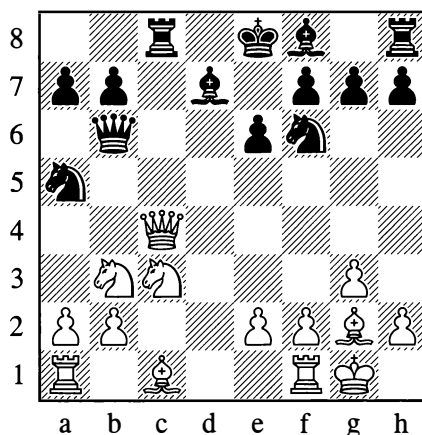
Black serious problems. For instance, 13.♟a4 ♟xa4 14.♞xa4† ♟e7 15.♟xc5† ♞xc5 16.♞ac1 ♞hc8 17.♞a3 ♟e8 was close to equal in Hardicsay – Oger, email 2009.

11...♟a5

This was played in both of the existing games from this position.

I also considered 11...♞b4N, but 12.♞xb4 ♟xb4 13.♞d1 0–0 (or 13...b6 14.♟b5) 14.♟e4! leads to a typical endgame edge for White.

11...♟e7N is well met by 12.♟e3 ♞c7 13.♟f4!, intending 13...e5 14.♟g5 ♟e6 15.♞a4 0–0 16.♟xf6 ♟xf6 17.♟c5 with some advantage.

**12.♞h4!N**

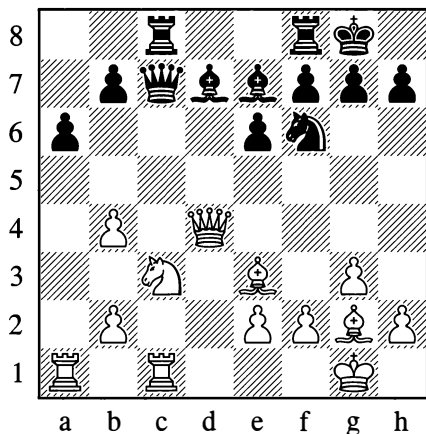
White needs to improve on the harmless 12.♞d4 ♞xd4 13.♟xd4, as played in Miguel Lago – Almagro Mazariegos, Linares 1998, when 13...♟b4N would have given Black a comfortable game.

12...♟xb3

12...♟e7 13.♟xa5 ♞xa5 14.♟xb7 ♞b8 15.♟f3 0–0 16.a3 can be compared with the later variation D32. Here White has a better version of the position with an extra pawn.

13.axb3 d7 14.b4!

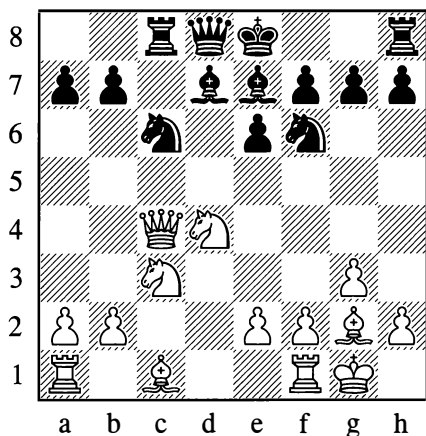
White maintains definite pressure, for instance:

14...a6 15.dxc3 c7 16.d4 0-0 17.fxc1**17...e5**

Also after 17...dxc6 18.b5 dxc2 19.cxc2 b8 20.c4 White maintains the more active position.

18.cxd3 b8 19.d5 dxd5 20.dxd5

White's excellent piece activity means that Black still faces a battle for equality.

D2) 10...d7

This is a pretty solid option for Black, but solid does not necessarily mean equalizing.

11.d1 d5

Other options are worse:

11...a5

White may use the exposed position of the queen to develop his initiative. Recently a new move appealed to me:

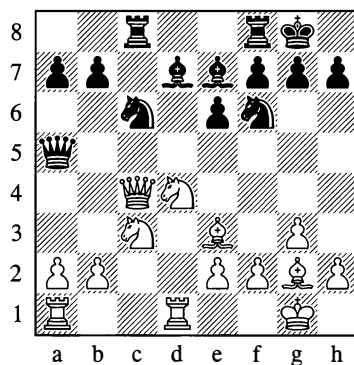
12.dxc3! N

Previously I recommended 12.dxc3, but things are not so simple after 12...h5!.

12...0-0

12...dxc3 13.cxc3 b6 14.dxc3 0-0 15.f4 dxc4 16.a4 gives Black problems connected with his bad queen position.

12...dxc4 13.cxc4 d5 14.c5 clearly favours White. One illustrative line is 14...b6 15.dxc5 dxc5 16.b8+ c8 17.cxb7 cxb7 18.dxb7 b8 19.dxc4! dxc4 20.dxc4 cxb2 21.ab1 cxb1 22.cxb1 and White will win the a-pawn, reaching a winning endgame.

**13.cxb5! c7**

13...cxb5 14.dxc5 is obviously better for White.

14.dxc6 dxc6 15.dxc6 bxc6

Black must weaken his pawn structure, since 15...cxc6 runs into 16.dxa7 cxb5 17.dxb5 c2 18.d4 cxe2 19.cac1 with a big plus for White.

16. ♖a6 ♜b8 17. b3±

White has a pleasant edge, as is customary for this pawn structure.

11... ♖b6 12. ♘xc6 ♙xc6 13. ♙e3 ♖a5

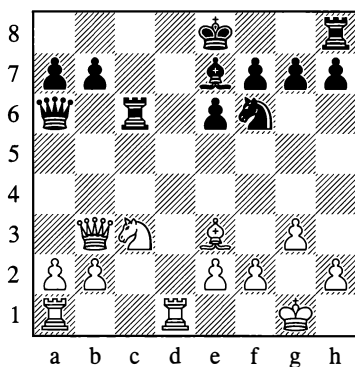
13... ♖xb2? is no good: 14. ♜ab1 ♖c2 The most stubborn attempt. (14... ♖a3? was played in Korniushev – Kofanov, Novgorod 1997, and here 15. ♘b5N+– followed by ♘xa7 would have decided the game on the spot.) 15. ♙xc6+ bxc6 (15... ♙xc6? 16. ♖xc6+! bxc6 17. ♜b8+ ♙d8 18. ♜bxd8+ ♙e7 19. ♙c5 is mate!) 16. ♙d2 ♖f5 17. ♜b7! White has a winning advantage.

14. ♙xc6+ ♙xc6

Black can hardly hope to equalize with 14... bxc6, and after 15. ♖a4! ♖xa4 16. ♘xa4 ♘d5 17. ♙d4 White's advantage is obvious.

15. ♖b3 ♖a6

Now in Shlykov – Kunitson, Narva 2006, White could have played more energetically with:



16. ♙d4!N

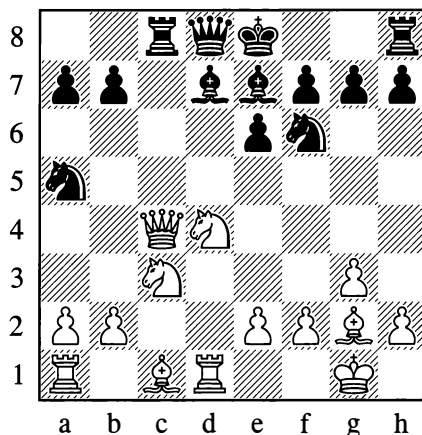
With the unpleasant threat of ♜a4.

16... ♖b6 17. ♖xb6 axb6

Worse is 17... ♙xb6 18. ♙c4!, when 18... ♙xb2? loses to 19. ♙c8+ ♙d8 20. ♙d1 ♘d7 21. ♘a4! followed by ♘c5.

18. ♙ad1 0–0 19. ♙a4

Black faces a difficult endgame in view of the weak pawns on b6 and b7.



12. ♙d3 0–0

Now White must play energetically to prevent Black from developing his pieces freely.

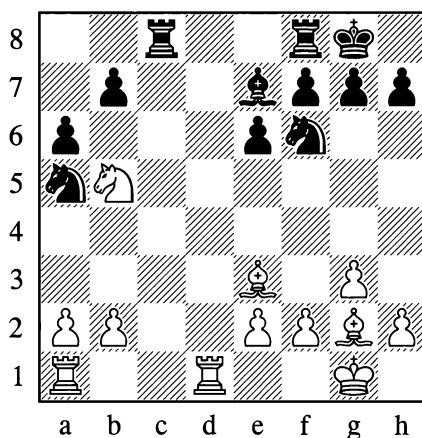
13. ♘db5 ♖b6

13... ♙xb5?! 14. ♖xb5 ♖b6 15. ♖xb6 axb6 16. ♙f4± gave White an obvious advantage thanks to his bishop pair in Kraemer – Faibisovich, Bad Wiessee 2013.

14. ♙e3 ♙xb5 15. ♖xb5

15. ♘xb5?! ♙c5 allowed Black to equalize comfortably in M.M. Ivanov – Lie, Gausdal 1996. By exchanging queens, White gives himself better chances to exploit the bishop pair.

15... ♖xb5 16. ♘xb5 a6



17.♘d4N

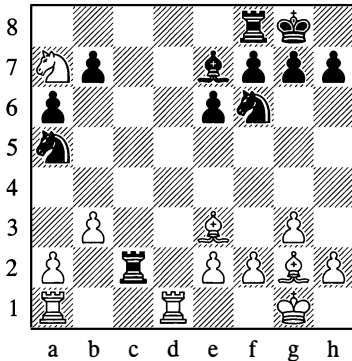
This improves over 17.♘d6 ♙xd6 18.♞xd6 ♘c4 19.♞d3 ♘xe3 20.♞xe3 ♞c7 with an easily holdable endgame for Black, Voelzke – Joppien, Kiel 2003.

17.♘a7!N

This alternative is ‘inhuman’, but the computer likes it.

17...♞c2 18.b3!

White should avoid 18.♞ac1?! ♞xb2 19.♞d2 ♞xd2 20.♙xd2 b6, when he has nothing better than 21.♙xa5 bxa5 22.♘c6= with a drawn endgame. Refusing the draw with 21.♘c8?! is rather dangerous in view of 21...♙c5 22.♞xc5 bxc5 23.♘e7† ♖h8 24.♙xa5 ♞b8! when White is in danger of losing the a-pawn.

**18...♘d5**

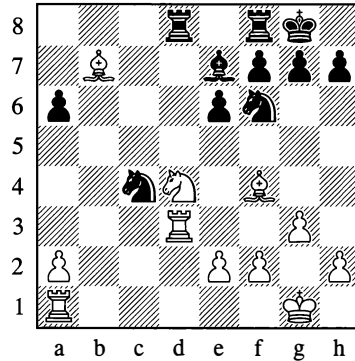
18...♞xe2?! 19.♙b6 ♙b4 20.a3 ♙c3 21.♞ac1 ♞d2 22.b4 ♘b3 23.♞xd2 ♙xd2 24.♞c7± gives White excellent winning chances.

19.♙xd5 exd5 20.♞xd5 ♙f6 21.♞c1 ♞xa2 22.b4 ♘b3 23.♞c7±

White's pieces are much more active.

17...♞fd8

Another line is 17...♘c4 18.♙f4! when the two bishops are starting to work: 18...♞cd8 19.♙xb7 ♘xb2 20.♞d2! ♘c4 21.♞d3



Black is under pressure, and 21...♘b2? is strongly met by 22.♘c6! ♘xd3 23.♘e7† ♖h8 24.exd3 ♞d7 25.♙xa6 ♞xe7 26.♙d6 with a winning endgame.

18.♞dc1!

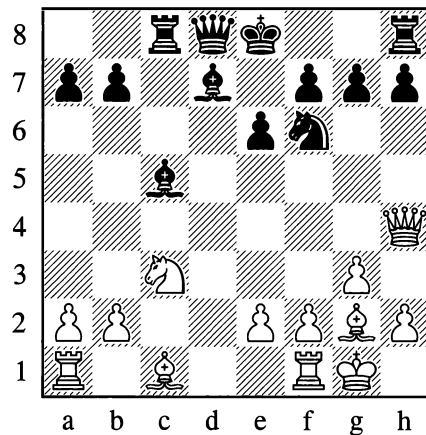
I prefer this over 18.♞ac1 ♞c4!.

18...♘d5

After 18...♞c4 19.♙d2! ♞xd4 20.♙xa5 White has a comfortable edge with his pair of bishops.

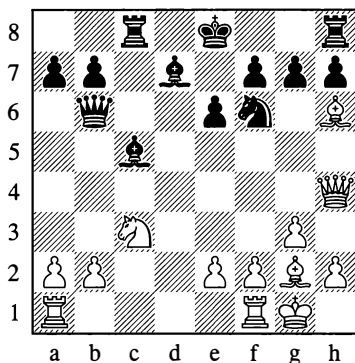
19.♞xc8 ♞xc8 20.♙xd5 exd5 21.b3±

White is slightly better, as he has easy play against the isolated pawn.

D3) 10...♘xd4 11.♞xd4 ♙c5 12.♞h4

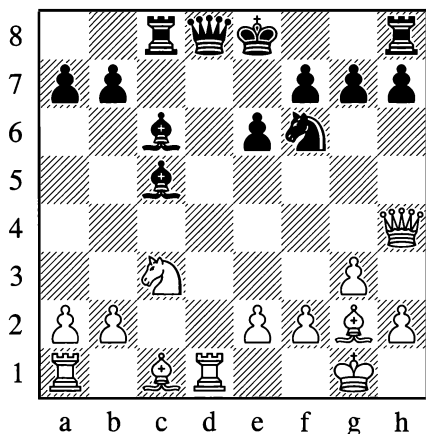
This way Black develops his bishop to a more active square, but in doing so he drives the queen to a good location where it sets up the thematic idea of ♙h6 . From here we will analyse **D31)** $12...\text{♙c6}$ followed by the main line of **D32)** $12...0-0$.

$12...\text{♝b6}$? allows the typical strike: $13.\text{♙h6}$!



$13...gxh6$ (Black's main problem is that $13...0-0?$ runs into $14.\text{♙xg7}!$ ♜xg7 $15.\text{♝g5}+$ with a winning advantage.) $14.\text{♝xf6}$ ♙d4 $15.\text{♝xh6}$ ♝xb2 $16.\text{♞e4}+$ Black is facing a dangerous attack with his king stuck in the centre, Zigura – Mancini, Massy 1993.

D31) $12...\text{♙c6}$ $13.\text{♝d1}$



$13...\text{♝a5}$

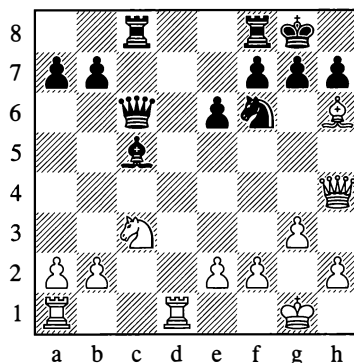
$13...\text{♝b6}$

This allows a familiar idea.

$14.\text{♙xc6}+$ ♝xc6

$14...\text{♝xc6}$ $15.\text{♙h6}!$ $gxh6$ $16.\text{♝xf6}$ $0-0$ $17.\text{♞e4}$ was clearly better for White in Portisch – Radulov, Buenos Aires (ol) 1978.

$15.\text{♙h6}$ $0-0$



$16.\text{♝ac1}!$ N

This is stronger than $16.\text{♙xg7}$ $\text{♙xf2}+$ $17.\text{♜xf2}$ $\text{♝c5}+$ $18.\text{♞g2}$ $\text{♜xg7}+$ when Black managed to hold the draw in G. Davies – Gysi, corr. 1995.

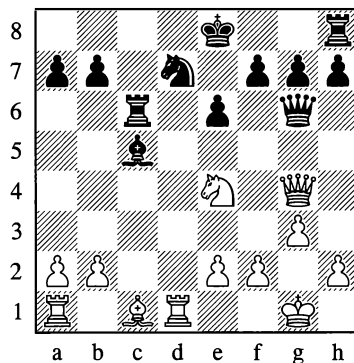
$16...e5$ $17.\text{♞a4}$ $b6$ $18.\text{♙e3}+$

White has a serious advantage.

$13...\text{♞d7}$ $14.\text{♙xc6}$ ♝xc6 $15.\text{♝g4}$

White should keep the queens on the board. $15.\text{♝xd8}+?$ ♜xd8 $16.\text{♙f4}$ ♜e7 gave Black nothing to worry about in Grigoryan – Hayrapetian, Yerevan 2013.

$15...\text{♝f6}$ $16.\text{♞e4}$ ♝g6

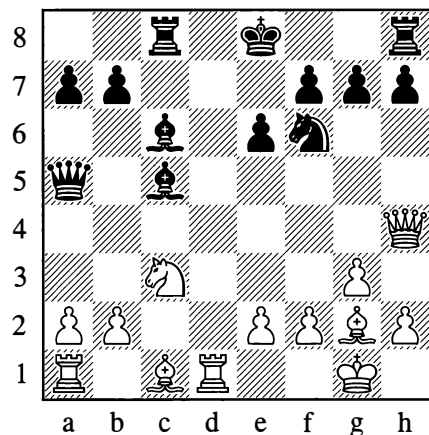


17. ♖f3!N

This is stronger than 17. ♖f4 e5 18. ♖f3 as in Hoffmann – Bartels, St Ingbert 1999. Here Black has a surprising resource in 18...♙d4!N 19. e3 ♙b6, when White can hardly develop much of an initiative with his bishop blocked in.

17...♙e7 18. ♙e3 f5 19. ♖c3 a6 20. ♖ac1

There is no doubting White's advantage.



14. ♙xc6† ♖xc6 15. ♙g5!

Now 15. ♙h6 is not so strong in view of 15...0-0 16. ♙xg7 ♙xf2† 17. ♙xf2 ♙xg7 with unclear play, Csom – Peters, Hastings 1978.

15...♙e7 16. ♖e4 ♖e5

16...♖f5 17. ♙xf6 ♙xf6 18. ♖xf6† ♖xf6 just transposes.

17. ♖xf6† ♙xf6

17...gxf6 18. ♙h6! leaves Black's king stuck in the centre.

18. ♙xf6 ♖xf6

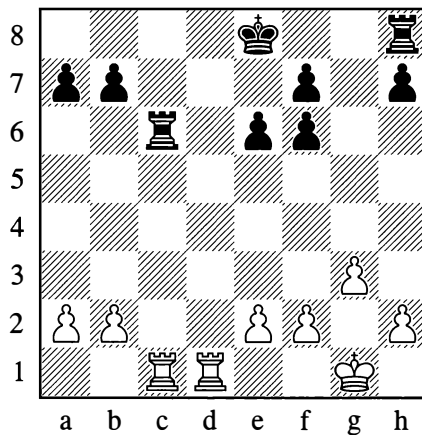
In the event of 18...gxf6 19. ♖g4 h5 20. ♖g7 ♖f8 21. ♖d2 ♙e7 22. ♖ad1 ♖c7 23. h4± Black is doomed to a passive defence.

19. ♖xf6

After 19. ♖b4 ♖e7! 20. ♖d4 0-0 21. ♖xa7 ♖c2 Black was fine and a draw was agreed in F. Olafsson – Ciric, Wijk aan Zee 1969.

19...gxf6 20. ♖ac1

This innocent-looking endgame is actually quite dangerous for Black.



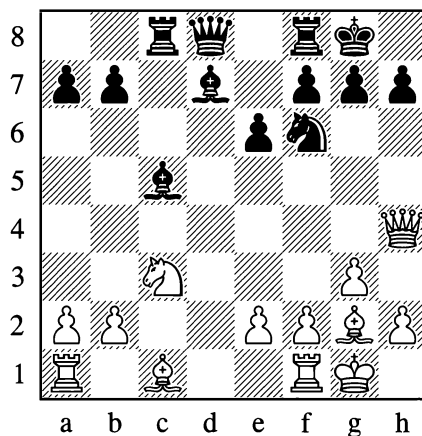
20...♙e7

After 20...♖xc1 21. ♖xc1 ♙d7 22. ♙g2± Black's problem is that 22...♖c8 is impossible, as White can exchange rooks and march his king towards the h7-pawn.

21. ♖xc6 bxc6 22. ♖d4 ♖b8 23. b3 ♖b5 24. ♖a4 a5 25. ♙g2±

The game Lein – P. Littlewood, Hastings 1980, demonstrated that it is by no means easy for Black to hold this endgame.

D32) 12...0-0

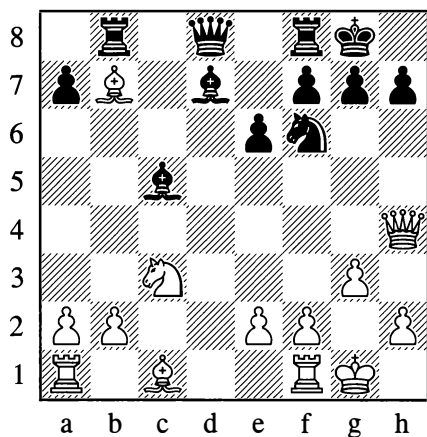


I faced this move the very next day after *GM 1* was launched, in a match between Israel and Denmark at the 2008 Dresden Olympiad. My opponent was Peter Heine Nielsen, one of the world's top theoreticians. I had noticed this idea when writing my first book, but it was rather unexplored. Nowadays there are over fifty games in the database.

13. ♖xb7

White has to accept the challenge if he is to fight for an advantage. There are several games showing that 13. ♖g5 h6 14. ♖xf6 ♜xf6 15. ♜xf6 gxf6 16. ♖xb7 ♜b8 17. ♖f3 ♜xb2= gives Black nothing to worry about.

13... ♜b8



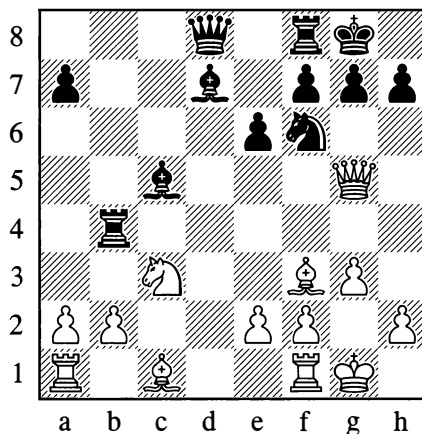
14. ♖f3

I gave this as a novelty in *GM 1*, and it has since been played in a lot of games.

One of the key differences with 14. ♖g2 is control over the g4-square. 14... ♜b4 15. ♜g5 ♜b6 16. a3 (The previous point is illustrated after 16. b3 ♖g4! 17. ♖d1 h6 18. ♜d2 ♖d4 19. ♜c2 ♜c8 when Black has a lot of activity.) 16... ♜c4 17. ♜d2 ♖c6 18. ♖xc6 This was Batchuluun – Omar, Istanbul (ol) 2012, and now the simple 18... ♜xc6N would have left Black with sufficient compensation.

14... ♜b4 15. ♜g5

Obviously White should refrain from e2-e4, as this would lose control over the d4-square while leaving White's queen cut off from the centre.



15... ♖d4

15... ♜b6? allows 16. b3 when White develops more comfortably. 16... h6 17. ♜d2 e5 was played in Nyback – Brunello, Rijeka 2010, and now 18. e3N ♖c6 19. ♖xc6 ♜xc6 20. ♖d1 would have left Black with no compensation for the missing pawn.

16. ♜d2

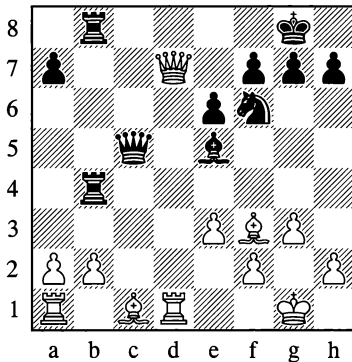
16. ♖d1 has been played a couple of times, but I am not completely happy with the position after 16... ♜b6!?N.

16... ♜c7 17. ♖d1!

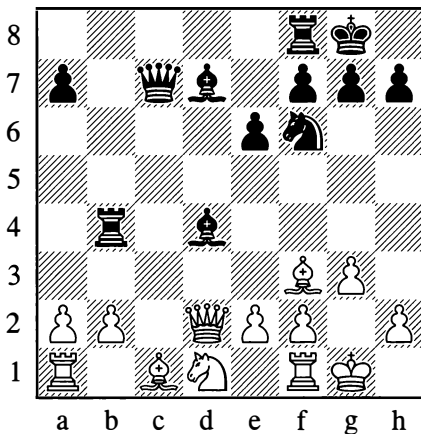
This move was first employed by Kramnik against Naiditsch, and I now believe it to be White's best.

17. ♜d3 was my superficial recommendation from *GM 1*. However, it is hardly dangerous for Black in view of 17... e5 18. ♖d1 ♖c6 19. ♖xc6 ♜xc6, when it is hard for White to untangle his queenside without returning his extra pawn. This has been tested in some correspondence games, all of which ended in draws.

17.♗d1 was my choice in 2008, but I got nowhere after 17...♗fb8 18.♖d3 ♖c5 19.e3 ♗e5 20.♖e4 ♖xe4 21.♖xd7 ♖f6



22.♖c6 ♖xc6 23.♗xc6 ♗xb2 24.♖b1 g5 and a draw was soon agreed in Avrukh – P.H. Nielsen, Dresden (ol) 2008.



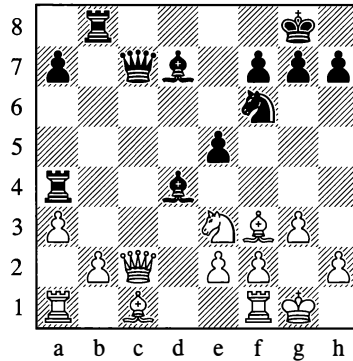
17...♗fb8

17...♖b6 has been played in one game, and here 18.♖b1N appeals to me the most. (18.♖e3 ♖c8 19.♖c2 ♗xb2 20.♖xb4 ♖xb4 21.♖xb4 ♗xa1 22.♗e3 ♗c3 was fine for Black in Li – Alavi Moghaddam, Zaozhuang 2012.) 18...e5 19.b3 White should be able to solve his queenside problems and remain with a healthy extra pawn, as seen after 19...♖c8 20.♗b2 ♗h3 21.♖e1 and so on.

18.a3 ♖c4

An important alternative is:
18...♖a4 19.♖e3 e5 20.♖c2!

The key point. Now Black has tried a few different queen moves.



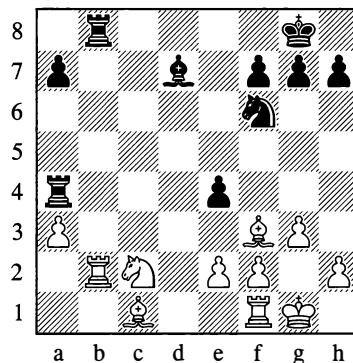
20...♖xc2

20...♖a5 is not the best square for the queen. I suggest the surprising novelty: 21.♗c6!N (I found that 21.b4 is not that clear. White went on to score a beautiful win in Kaidanov – Yang, Saint Louis 2011, but Black's play can be improved.) 21...♗xc6 22.♖xc6 ♖b5 23.♖xb5 ♖xb5 24.♖f5 White has a healthy extra pawn.

20...♖d8 21.♖b1!N Another important novelty. (21.♖f5? ♖c8 22.♖b3 ♖b8 23.♖c2 ♖c8 24.♖d1 ♖ac4 gave Black a lot of compensation in Yanayt – Yang, Arlington 2011.) 21...♖c8 22.♖d2 ♗xe3 Otherwise White will just play b2-b3. 23.♖xe3 ♗f5 24.♖a1 e4 25.♗g2! Black does not have enough for the pawn.

21.♖xc2 ♗xb2 22.♖b1 e4 23.♖xb2

23.♗g2 ♗e5 is close to equal.

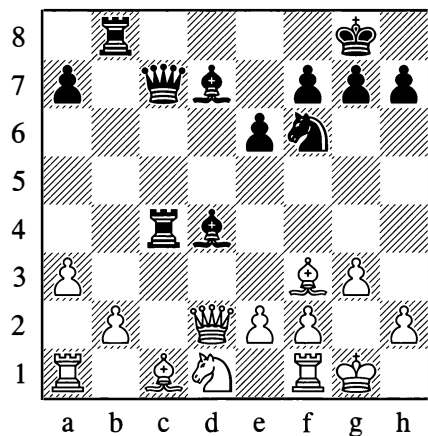


23...♖xb2

23...♖c8 24.♗g2 ♖ac4 25.♗g5 ♖xc2 26.♖xc2 ♖xc2 27.♗d1 reaches an endgame where Black will be tortured for a long time by the bishop pair.

24.♗xb2 exf3 25.exf3

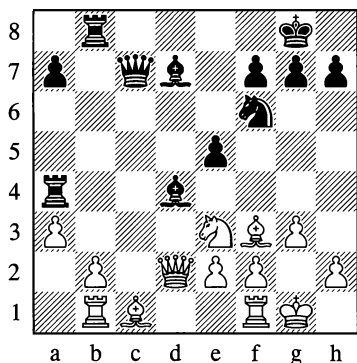
White has a solid extra pawn with several pieces remaining. His winning chances are quite real, although the opposite-coloured bishops give Black some hopes of salvation.



19.♖e3 ♗xe3

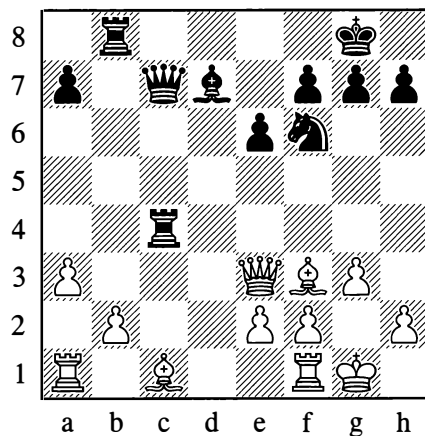
This improvement over the stem game was recommended in different sources, and has been tested in some correspondence games.

Black is short of resources after: 19...♖a4 20.♖b1 e5 (20...♗xe3 21.♖xe3 ♖d5 22.♖d3 ♗b5 23.♖d1± leaves White with a healthy extra pawn.)



This position occurred in Kramnik – Naiditsch, Dortmund 2010, and now 21.b3!N is the most convincing continuation. (In the game White played 21.b4 and won in good style, but Black could have made things more difficult.) 21...♖a6 22.♗b2 ♗xb2 23.♖xb2 e4 24.♗g2± Black has no real targets for counterplay.

20.♖xe3



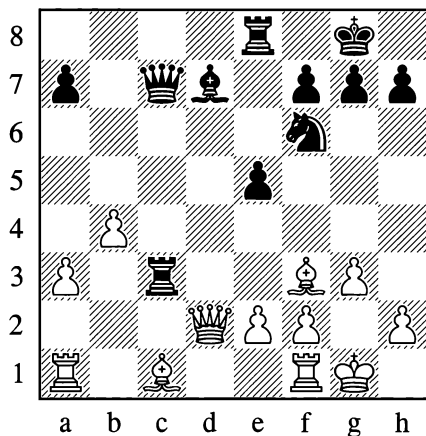
20...e5 21.b4

I remember seeing 21.♗d2 ♖xb2 22.♖ab1 recommended somewhere, with a supposed advantage for White, due to his bishop pair. However, after 22...♖xb1 23.♖xb1 h6, Black seems totally fine.

21...♖c3 22.♖d2 ♖e8!?

22...♖c2 23.♖d3 ♖e8 24.♗g2 ♗g4 25.♖b3 ♗e6 26.♖b1 led to an eventual victory for Black in Bobarnac – Kovalsky, corr. 2011, but the result was due to White's subsequent mistakes. At this point Black does not have sufficient compensation.

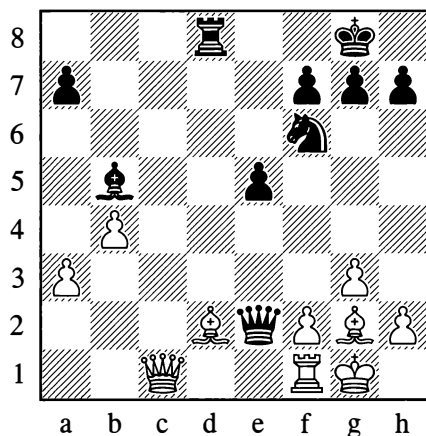
The text move occurred in Antonenko – Foulds, corr. 2013. This is incredibly tricky play from Black, who is trying to stay flexible, while White is suffering from a lack of activity. However, I believe I have found a suitable solution.

**23.♙g2N**

My idea is to give up the extra pawn, in return for activating the dark-squared bishop. The following illustrative line looks most logical to me.

23...♙b5 24.♖d1 ♘d8 25.♙d2 ♖c4

25...♙c2 is not dangerous in view of 26.♙c1.

26.♙c1 ♙xc1 27.♖xc1 ♖xe2**28.♙e3**

White has the bishop pair and should be able to create a passed pawn on the queenside, which makes his chances clearly preferable.

Conclusion

After 5...c5 6.0-0 ♘c6 7.♖a4, the 7...♙d7 variation remains an important battleground, with many new games having occurred since *GM 1* was published. After the automatic 8.♖xc4 we looked at four main options.

8...♙c8 and 8...♖b6 are playable, but both moves suffer from a similar problem. The point is that, after 9.dxc5, recapturing the c5-pawn will require Black to misplace his pieces in one way or another, thus ensuring a slight initiative for White.

8...b5 is an interesting move, although it carries certain strategic risks after 9.♖d3. Black may proceed with the space-gaining 9...c4, but this grants White full control over the centre. On the other hand, if he maintains the tension with 9...♙c8, then 10.dxc5 ♙xc5 11.♘c3 leaves him with some holes on the queenside, as well as a bishop that would be better placed on b7 than on d7.

The most solid and popular option is 8...cxd4 9.♘xd4 ♙c8, when the main line continues 10.♘c3 ♘xd4 11.♖xd4 ♙c5 12.♖h4. Now 12...♙c6 allows White to develop his initiative, putting Black under pressure without taking much risk. The most critical line is 12...0-0, when 13.♙xb7 ♖b8 14.♙f3 reaches a key position that has been tested many times since *GM 1* was published. The position is challenging for both sides, but my overall feeling is that Black does not have quite enough activity for the sacrificed pawn.